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Page 1 — Cover

Japan Winter Trip Planner

Snow, onsen, ski, illuminations & winter food — plan a flexible cold-season trip.

A planning tool, not a guarantee. Snow and seasonal events shift every year — always check current-year updates.

Page 2 — How Winter in Japan Works (Read First)

Winter is roughly December through February, but conditions vary enormously by region. The right plan depends on which kind of winter you're chasing.

- The north and mountains get serious snow. Northern and high-elevation areas can have heavy, reliable snowfall — great for skiing and snow scenery, but expect cold and possible transport delays.
- Much of the Pacific side is cold but drier. Many major cities see crisp, often sunny winter days with little snow, which is easier for sightseeing.
- Seasonal events have fixed windows. Illuminations, snow festivals, and some onsen towns run only for set dates that change yearly — always confirm current dates.
- Daylight is short. Plan outdoor activities earlier; evenings are long, which is perfect for illuminations and onsen.
- Closures happen. Some seasonal spots, trails, and ferries pause in winter. Build buffer time.

> Hedge tip: leave at least one flexible buffer day per week for snow delays or closures.

Page 3 — Choose Your Winter (Theme Overview)

Pick one or two themes to anchor your trip. Each table is a starting point — confirm current-year details before booking.

Theme	What it's for	Typical region type	Watch out for
Snow scenery	Photogenic snow towns, snowscapes	North / mountain areas	Cold, transport delays
Onsen	Hot springs, ryokan stays	Mountain & rural onsen towns	Etiquette, booking ahead
Ski & snowboard	Powder, resorts	Northern & alpine resorts	Lift hours, gear rental
Illuminations	City light displays	Major cities	Fixed dates, crowds
Winter food	Seasonal seafood, hot pot, citrus	Coastal & nationwide	Seasonal availability

My chosen theme(s): _____

Why this theme: _____

Page 4 — Winter Region Snapshot

A rough orientation only. Always confirm current conditions and access.

Region type	Best for	Snow level (general)	Notes
Far north	Snow, ski, festivals	Heavy	Coldest; pack accordingly
Northern alps / highlands	Ski, snow towns	Heavy	Scenic; check road access
Central cities	Sightseeing, illuminations	Light	Easiest travel
Western cities	Culture, food, light snow	Light-moderate	Mild vs north
Southern islands	Mild escape	None-rare	Warmest winter option

Regions I'm considering: _____

Page 5 — Day-by-Day Itinerary (with Hedge Column)

Copy this page for each day. The hedge column is for your backup plan if snow or closures hit.

Time	Plan	Area / transport	Hedge / backup
Morning			
Midday			
Afternoon			
Evening			

- Weather check done? ☒ Transport running? ☒ Indoor backup ready? ☒
- Notes: _____

Page 6 — Ski & Snow Day Checklist

For resort or snow-activity days. Confirm lift hours and rental availability in advance.

- ☒ Lift hours & day-pass price confirmed (check latest)
- ☒ Gear: rent on site or bring? _____
- ☒ Base + mid + waterproof outer layers
- ☒ Waterproof gloves, hat, neck warmer, goggles/sunglasses
- ☒ Hand/foot warmers
- ☒ Lunch plan (resort food can sell out)
- ☒ Last lift / last bus time noted: _____
- ☒ Beginner lessons booked? ☒
- Notes: _____

Page 7 — Onsen Etiquette Quick-Guide

General etiquette for hot springs. Customs vary by facility — read posted signs.

- Wash first. Rinse and wash thoroughly at the shower stations before entering the bath.
- No swimwear in most traditional baths; a small towel is for washing, not the water.
- Tie up long hair and keep towels out of the bath water.
- Quiet and calm. No splashing, swimming, or loud talk.
- Tattoos: some facilities restrict them — check the venue's current policy or look for tattoo-friendly options.
- Hydrate before and after; don't soak too long if you feel lightheaded.

Onsen I want to visit: _____

Page 8 — Winter Food Bucket List

Seasonal items vary by region and availability. Tick what you try.

- ☒ Hot pot / nabe (shared simmered dishes)
- ☒ Ramen on a cold day
- ☒ Winter seafood (crab, oysters, hot-pot fish)
- ☒ Oden (simmered street/convenience food)
- ☒ Roasted sweet potato (yaki-imo)
- ☒ Winter citrus / seasonal fruit
- ☒ Warm sake or hot tea
- ☒ Steamed buns / hot snacks from convenience stores
- My own picks: _____

Page 9 — Winter Packing Checklist (Layering)

Layering beats one thick coat. Adjust for north vs city trips.

Layers

- ☒ Thermal base layers (top & bottom)
- ☒ Warm mid-layers (fleece/knit)
- ☒ Insulated, ideally water-resistant coat
- ☒ Warm trousers / lined leggings

Extremities

- ☒ Gloves, hat/beanie, scarf or neck warmer
- ☒ Warm, waterproof footwear + grippy soles (icy pavements)
- ☒ Thick socks (spare pairs)
- ☒ Hand/foot warmers

Other

- ☒ Lip balm & moisturizer (dry air)

- ☒ Power bank (cold drains batteries)
- ☒ Small umbrella / waterproof
- ☒ Medications & essentials
- Notes: _____

Page 10 — Budget Jotter

Rough estimates only; confirm current prices.

Category	Planned	Actual
Transport		
Accommodation		
Ski / activities		
Onsen / entries		
Food		
Other		
Total		

Page 11 — Pre-Trip Final Check

- ☒ Buffer day(s) built in for snow/closures
- ☒ Seasonal event dates confirmed (illuminations/festivals) — check latest
- ☒ Ryokan / onsen / resort bookings confirmed
- ☒ Transport routes & winter timetables checked
- ☒ Warm, waterproof footwear sorted
- ☒ Offline maps & key info saved on phone
- Final notes: _____

End of planner. Have a warm, flexible winter trip. Always verify current-year snow, dates, hours, and prices before you go.